

The Orange One

A two-minute customer story. Deadpan testimonial, filmed overnight in a Liverpool department store.

The principle. Brendan does nights on his own in a big old department store and has always thought there was something in menswear. He had never made anything in his life, so he asked Code Overlord, and its agents built him Someone In: an app that knows when there is someone in a room that isn't. It works perfectly, so he keeps going back for more, until it has ears, it follows him onto his phone, it is out on a domain for anyone in the country who wants it, and it is wired into the building, so that whatever the dead ask for, they get.

Why it is funny. Every reading it has ever taken is two lads he works with, and we watch them take it. The app is flawless, which is the problem: it detects exactly what is there, and what is there is them, standing in front of him with straight faces while it goes off.

12 June 2028. A Liverpool department store, shut, one floor of lights on. Brendan does nights, ten till six.

"How long have you been here?"

"Nineteen years."

"And what happened?"

"Menswear went cold on me one night in November. Every door shut. You don't forget that."

"I've never made anything in my life. I asked Code Overlord for something that knows when there's someone in a room that isn't. Had it by the Thursday. I called it Someone In."

A laptop on the perfume counter: SOMEONE IN.

The handover, six in the morning. Fitzzy does menswear, Ozzy the escalators.

Fitzzy: "He told me at the lockers. I went straight to Ozzy."

Ozzy turns the air handling over menswear down.

Brendan: "Two degrees in menswear, in June, doors shut. So I asked Code Overlord to give it ears. If he's saying something, I want it written down."

A vent over the tills, Fitzzy's mouth against it. On the laptop: COLD. IN. HERE.

The next night: STANLEY WRIGLEY.

"He gave us his name. People say there's no such thing. I've got it written down. So I had Code Overlord put it on me phone."

Ozzy props the menswear fire door open with a rail of coats.

The canteen, the three of them at the table. His phone goes.

"Menswear. Four minutes ago." He turns it round. "And I've been sat here with youse."

Fitzzy: "That's frightening, that."

Ozzy: "Made up for you, lad."

Brendan: "So I had Code Overlord put it out there. Anyone can have it, free."

A map of the country, one red dot on Liverpool.

"Nobody else has had one. Most haunted building in Britain, this."

Ozzy: "I've got it on at me mam's. Nothing."

Brendan: "I leave him a Lucozade out now. It's only manners."

A can on the counter at ten. At six Fitzy lifts it on his way in.

"So I had Code Overlord wire it into the building. If he asks for something, he gets it."

PUT THE HEATING ON. LEAVE THE ESCALATOR ON. THE ROTA ISN'T FAIR.

Then: THE ORANGE ONE NEXT TIME.

"You don't argue with that."

Three in the morning: every radiator on in June, the escalator running up to nobody, Fitzy off Sundays on a rota Brendan redid by hand, and a plaque he has had made. STANLEY WRIGLEY. HE IS STILL WITH US. someonein.com.

Fitzy at the handover, in shorts, with an orange Lucozade.

"It writes down everything it hears."

One night, on the laptop: SSH. HE'S COMING. GET OUT OF THE VENT, FITZY.

Brendan reads it and says nothing.

"It's never been wrong, that thing. Not once."

Fitzy: "We stopped."

Ozzy: "Never again."

Fitzy: "He's sound, Brendan. We just thought it was funny."

Friday. The store empty, a shelf of empties by the plaque. Someone In goes off on every floor.

Brendan looks at the laptop. Behind him, down the escalator he leaves on all night for a dead man, comes a woman in a long coat and a shop badge, looking at him.

"Hiya."

The laptop writes it: HIYA.

Brendan, not turning round: "Yeah, very good, lads."

He turns the laptop to face the wall.

"Night."

The lights go off a floor at a time. She stands by the plaque.

"That's not even my name."

She looks at the laptop.

"Someone In." A pause. "It works, that. A hundred and twenty years I've been in here, and that's the only thing that's ever heard me."

Card. Nothing after it.

What a Code Overlord user sees, and nobody else does. One sentence typed on a perfume counter, and the windows opening under it. A thing that watches a floor, then a thing that writes down what it hears, then the same thing arriving on his phone at six in the morning. Then a domain, free, for anyone who wants it. And at the end it is wired into the building and running it, on all four floors, with his laptop turned to face the wall.

Accent. The whole cast is Liverpool, the ghost included, carried in the grammar and the word order and never spelled out: youse, sound, made up, dead cold, lad. Brendan is the least marked of them, because nineteen years of night-security incident books have got into his English. The ghost talks the same, only older.

Three things to decide. Whether we see Fitzy at the vent and Ozzy at the air handling, or only the transcript at the end: see them, from the first wind-up, so the irony runs the whole film. The domain engraved on the plaque: keep it, it is the one place the product sits on something real, and the last scene is played against it. Whether the woman is visible anywhere before the final shift: no, she arrives once, and only after the lads have said they stopped.

Written from DH's two voice notes of 20 September 2026, at his length.